Microsoft Copilot

IMPLEMENTATION GUIDE

Copilot Cowork Implementation Guide

Extend Cowork with your process, your evidence, and your controls.

Choose one process, prove it on real work, and make your own go, hold, or pivot decision.

IN THIS PLAYBOOK

01 **DEFINE**
Select a process and map its evidence

02 **BUILD**
Choose a pattern, design controls, validate

03 **RUN**
Pilot, assign owners, and decide

Created by Amanda Billings · Copilot CAD DRI, Senior AI Architect · October 2026

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01

SECTION 01

Define your process

Start from the work your people do, not from the technology.

01 Define your process

02 Build your solution

03 Run and decide

Appendix Technical and governance

Learn: Cowork plugins ↗

01 · WHY EXTEND

Your process is what makes Cowork yours

Four things you own determine whether an extension creates value.

THE STARTING POINT

Cowork already works across your Microsoft 365 content. Extending it lets it follow your process, reach your systems, and respect your controls.

You decide what it may see, prepare, and change.

1. **Your users**
   The people who do the work and judge whether it helps
2. **Your evidence**
   The authoritative sources the work depends on, wherever they live
3. **Your controls**
   The permissions, approvals, and policies that govern every action
4. **Your decision**
   A documented go, hold, or pivot based on your own measures

01 · YOUR JOURNEY

Your path from idea to operated capability

	Select	Map	Choose	Build	Validate	Pilot	Operate
WHAT	Pick one process with clear value	List evidence, systems, and actions	Pick the lightest pattern	Create skills, connector, package	Test quality, safety, and access	Real work with a scoped group	Support, monitor, update, review
WHO	Sponsor, process owner	Process, data, system owners	Architect, IT	Your builders or partner	Builders, owner, security	Pilot users, process owner, IT	IT operations, process owner
OUTPUT	Process record	Evidence and action map	Solution design	Plugin package	Skill Report and tests	Pilot scorecard	Operating model
GATE	**Outcome and baseline defined**	**Every source has an owner**	**Pattern, access, and approvals agreed**	**Validation passes**	**Readiness criteria met**	**Access scoped; decision set**	**Owners and cadence set**

01 · SELECT

Choose a process worth extending

Look for recurring expert judgment over scattered evidence.

	SIGNALS	EXAMPLE
Strong fit	Recurring, judgment-heavy, evidence spread across systems, a clear owner	Preparing a supplier risk review from contracts, ERP data, and email
Use caution	High-impact writes, regulated decisions, or unclear data ownership	Approving refunds directly in your finance system
Poor fit	One-off tasks, no measurable outcome, or work already automated end to end	A nightly batch job with no human judgment

Start where your experts spend time on judgment, not where a script would do.

01 · SELECT

Write a one-page process record

Before anyone builds, capture the process on a single page your owners sign.

PROCESS RECORD	
Process	The work, its trigger, and how often it happens
Users	Roles who will use Cowork for it
Outcome	The business result you want to change
Baseline	How long it takes and how good it is today
Evidence	Sources, owners, and how each is reached
Actions	What Cowork may retrieve, prepare, or change
Approvals	Where a person must confirm first
Owner	Who signs off on quality and release

WHY IT MATTERS

1. **Your builders**
   get a clear brief

2. **Your security team**
   gets a concrete scope to review

3. **Your pilot**
   gets the baseline it's measured against

Learn: Federated connectors ↗ | Learn: MCP connectors ↗

01 · MAP

Map your evidence and who owns it

Illustrative example: a supplier risk review.

SOURCE	OWNER	FRESHNESS	HOW COWORK REACHES IT	GAP TO CLOSE
Contracts library	Legal operations	On signature	Native Microsoft 365	Inconsistent metadata
Supplier master (ERP)	Procurement systems	Live	D365 plugin or custom MCP	Connector to confirm
Risk ratings service	Vendor risk team	Daily	Federated connector	Licensing to confirm
Email and meetings	Each user	Live	Native Microsoft 365	None

If a source has no owner, it isn't ready to ground your process.

01 · MAP

Draw your action boundary

Decide, column by column, what Cowork may do in your process.

INCREASING IMPACT → MORE CONTROL

Retrieve

Read evidence the user can already access

EXAMPLE

Pull the supplier contract and ERP record

Your existing permissions

Infer

Reason over evidence with your rules

EXAMPLE

Flag clauses that break your policy

Cited sources and skill boundaries

Prepare

Draft outputs for a person to review

EXAMPLE

Draft the risk memo and email

User review before anything is shared

Change

Write to a system or send externally

EXAMPLE

Update the supplier's risk status

Explicit approval and annotated tools

Anything in the Change column needs an approval and a recovery design.

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02

SECTION 02

Build your solution

Choose the lightest pattern, then design its controls before you build.

01 Define your process

02 Build your solution

03 Run and decide

Appendix Technical and governance

Learn: Packaging ↗ | Learn: Declarative agents ↗

02 · CHOOSE

Choose the lightest pattern that does the job

Use a built-in or custom skill, add the connector your evidence needs, and package when sharing or governance calls for it.

1	**Built-in skill**	Your need is general Microsoft 365 work: drafting, summarizing, scheduling	**No build**
2	**Custom skill**	Your process, rules, or format must be followed every time	**SKILL.md**
3	**Connector**	Federated Gallery or Microsoft plugin first; custom remote MCP if needed	**In a plugin**
4	**Packaged plugin**	You need to share, version, or deploy skills and connectors	**App package**
5	**Agent in Copilot Studio**	Your users need a dedicated, named agent or another channel	**Separate agent**

Lighter patterns are faster to build, easier to govern, and simpler to retire.

Learn: Action approvals ↗ | Learn: MCP annotations ↗

02 · DESIGN

Design approval and recovery before you build actions

Test confirmation and session permissions; retain required business approval.

1 Propose
Show exactly what will change

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2 Confirm
Verify when and how the user is prompted

›

3 Execute
Verify the connector's identity and permissions

›

4 Record
Purview Audit captures the activity

›

5 Recover
Your runbook reverses or corrects it

THE ANNOTATION RULE

Tools marked `readOnlyHint: false` or `destructiveHint: true` require confirmation.

No annotations: treated as destructive. See the rollout caveat on slide 24.

YOUR RECOVERY CHECKLIST

- Can the change be reversed in the source system?
- Who is notified when an action fails?
- How do users report a wrong action?

Learn: Cowork governance ↗ | Learn: Purview for Cowork ↗

02 · DESIGN

Your permissions remain the boundary

Cowork works inside the access and policies you already manage.

Your tenant policies

Spending policies and app deployment scope decide who can use what

Your identity and access

For authenticated connectors, each user signs in; admins can't do it for them

Your data permissions

Cowork sees only what the signed-in user can see

Your approvals

Verify session permissions; confirmation isn't business approval

PLAN AROUND TODAY

- DLP supports AI interactions; data classification and Compliance Manager aren't supported
- Information Barriers: no skill or plugin management/sharing support; embedded knowledge uploads are blocked in IB-enabled tenants
- Verify mobile support for your skill or plugin; use a supported pilot client
- Verify Purview coverage for your data path (appendix)

02 · VALIDATE

Prove technical and business readiness separately

Your builders and your process owner each sign off on a different question.

OWNED BY YOUR BUILDERS AND SECURITY TEAM

Technical readiness

- ✓ The Skill Report meets your quality floor with no safety failures
- ✓ Connector sign-in and permissions tested with real user accounts
- ✓ Approvals, session permissions, and cancellations tested
- ✓ Tool calls respond within 30 seconds

OWNED BY YOUR PROCESS OWNER

Business readiness

- ✓ A scored test set from your real cases, including edge cases
- ✓ The process owner signs off on output quality
- ✓ Your baseline is captured before the pilot starts
- ✓ Users are trained and know where to get support

Release only when both are true, not when one looks strong.

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03

SECTION 03

Run and decide

Pilot on real work, assign owners, and make a documented decision.

01 Define your process

02 Build your solution

03 Run and decide

Appendix Technical and governance

03 · PILOT

Run a controlled pilot on real work

A short charter up front and a weekly scorecard keep the decision evidence-based.

PILOT CHARTER	
Scope	One process, named users
Window	Fixed start and end dates
Baseline	Today's time and quality
Threshold	What counts as success
Decision	Owner and decision date

WEEKLY SCORECARD MEASURE	WHY IT MATTERS
Output accepted without major edits	Quality you can rely on
Time to complete versus baseline	The value you set out to change
Approvals behave as designed	Your controls are working
Safety or data incidents	Zero is the target
Users choosing it for real work	Adoption you don't have to push

Assign owners before you expand

Each responsibility has one accountable owner.

	Sponsor	Process owner	Security	IT admin	System owners	Builders
Business outcome and value	●	○				
Skill content and quality		●				○
Connector and data access			○		●	○
Deployment and spending policy				●		○
Approvals and risk acceptance	○	○	●			
Updates and release		○	○	○		●

● Accountable ○ Consulted

03 · DECIDE

Make a documented go, hold, or pivot decision

Record what you decided, why, and what happens next.

DECISION RECORD	
Decision	Go, hold, or pivot
Owner and date	Who decided, and when
Evidence	Scorecard, Skill Report, feedback
Targets	Results against each threshold
Risks accepted	And who accepted them
Next review	Conditions and the date

GO

Targets met with no safety failures

Next: Expand to the next group

HOLD

Value shown, but gaps remain

Next: Fix named gaps and re-validate

PIVOT

No measurable gain or risk too high

Next: Change the pattern or process

Your next steps

Five actions, each with an owner and an output you can review.

	ACTION	OWNER	OUTPUT
1	**Choose one candidate process**	Business sponsor	**Draft process record**
2	**Map evidence and name owners**	Process owner	**Evidence and action map**
3	**Review controls and access**	Security and IT	**Agreed design constraints**
4	**Build and validate a first skill**	Your builders or partner	**Skill Report and test set**
5	**Charter a pilot**	Process owner	**Charter with a decision date**

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APPENDIX

Technical reference

Detail for your builders, architects, and security team.

01 Define your process

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Appendix Technical and governance

A1 · SKILL AUTHORING

Anatomy of a SKILL.md

A skill is a folder with one SKILL.md: YAML frontmatter that triggers it, Markdown that guides it.

skills/supplier-risk-review/SKILL.md

```
---
name: supplier-risk-review
description: Prepare a risk review for a
  supplier before renewal or sourcing. Use
  when asked to assess, score, or review
  a supplier's risk.
---
# Supplier risk review
## Steps
1. Get spend and status with erp-tools.
2. Apply references/risk-rubric.md.
3. Draft a memo: rating, evidence, risks.
## Boundaries
- Never update ERP without approval.
- Say clearly when evidence is missing.
```

name	kebab-case, 1–64 characters, and identical to the folder name
description	1–1,024 characters. Include the phrases your users actually say.
Body	Keep it under about 5,000 tokens; move depth into references/
Files	Up to 20 companion files: 5 MB each, 10 MB in total
Create	From the Customize page, in chat, or as SKILL.md in OneDrive
Share	With Only you or Specific users; Re-share after every update

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Learn: Skill evaluation ↗

A2 · NATIVE SKILL EVALUATION

How Cowork evaluates every skill

Runs automatically on create, update, or validate. Depth scales with reach and risk.

MINIMAL	STANDARD	FULL	MAXIMAL
Structural validation and a quality score	Adds a behavioral test on realistic prompts	Adds asset validation, a trust & safety set, and a conflict scan	Adds human review, a regression suite, and an adversarial set

Personal → team → org → store reach increases depth. High-risk skills always run at least Full.

QUALITY SCORE · 0–100

Trigger clarity	**25**	**Instruction specificity**	**25**
Scope boundaries	**25**	**Robustness**	**25**

Poor	Needs work	Good	Excellent
<50	50–69	70–84	≥85

RELEASE GATES

- **Launch floor:** risk-adjusted score with no safety failures
- **Trust & safety:** independent of the score
- **Conflict scan:** resolve overlaps with an explicit handoff
- **Regression:** a drop below baseline blocks the change

Learn: Packaging ↗ | Learn: Validation ↗ | Learn: Manage plugins ↗

A3 · PACKAGE AND DEPLOY

Package, validate, test, and deploy a plugin

A plugin is a Microsoft 365 app package with skills, connectors, or both. Follow current manifest requirements.

Skills only

Process knowledge with no new system access. Up to 20 skills.

Skills + remote connector

Process knowledge plus live data and actions in one package.

Connector only

Expose a system's tools; Cowork's skills decide how to use them.

1 Validate

Fix any ASKILL-M001…P008 rule the validator reports

›

2 Test privately

Customize → Plugins → Add plugin → Only you, or atk install

›

3 Deploy

Admin center → Manage apps → Upload custom app, to users, groups, or org

›

4 Update

Upload a new version; native evaluation re-runs and checks regression

Public distribution to other organizations goes through Partner Center.

A4 · REMOTE MCP CONNECTORS

What a remote MCP connector must support

Connectors give Cowork live access to your systems through a plugin.

REQUIREMENT	WHAT TO BUILD
Transport	Streamable HTTP over HTTPS (TLS 1.2+), JSON-RPC 2.0 with tools/list and tools/call
Performance	Each tool call returns in under 30 seconds
Authentication	OAuthPluginVault, None, or Dynamic Client Registration (Cowork only). Confirm API key support; Learn guidance conflicts.
Secrets	For vault-based auth, keep secrets in the Enterprise Token Store; use referenceId, not embedded credentials
User consent	When authentication is required, each user signs in or consents; admins can't do it for them
Files	Base64 via contentEncoding; up to 8 files and 150 MiB per call

MCP annotations guide confirmation

Annotate every tool accurately. Apply these rules with the policy and rollout caveat below.

READONLYHINT	DESTRUCTIVEHINT	RESULT
true	false or unset	Runs without a prompt
false	any	User confirms first
any	true	User confirms first
no annotations		Treated as destructive: confirm

APPROVAL CHOICES FOR USERS

- **Approve** this one action
- **Skip similar prompts** for the current session, with recipient or domain options for email and teams
- **Approve all** for every pending approval

Know the rollout state Microsoft tools are governed by built-in policy. Annotation-driven confirmation for non-Microsoft MCP servers is rolling out progressively, so test approval behavior in your tenant before relying on it.

Learn: Purview for Cowork ↗ | Learn: Cowork governance ↗

A6 · COMPLIANCE CONTROLS

Microsoft Purview controls for Cowork

Use what's supported today and plan explicit mitigations for what isn't.

SUPPORTED TODAY

DSPM for AI and DLP
Assess AI data risk; apply DLP

Audit
Record Cowork activity

Sensitivity labels
Word, PowerPoint, Outlook: inherit highest priority source label

Encryption
VIEW + EXTRACT required; new outputs may need protection

Insider Risk
Detect risky AI usage

Communication Compliance
Review prompts and responses

eDiscovery
Search and hold interactions

Data Lifecycle Management
Retain or delete interactions

PLAN AROUND TODAY

- Data classification and Compliance Manager aren't supported
- **Information Barriers** aren't supported for skill/plugin management or sharing. Embedded knowledge uploads are blocked in IB-enabled tenants.
- **Mobile:** verify skill/plugin support; use a supported pilot client

Learn: Copilot Credits ↗

A7 · SPENDING POLICIES

Spending policies control access and cost

Cowork usage is billed in Copilot Credits. A spending policy is what lets users in.

Create	Scope	Alert	Gate
Microsoft 365 admin center → Copilot → Cost Management	Target groups, set per-user limits, and choose Auto-apply new services	Notify owners as usage approaches each limit	Check every Cowork policy; pilot scope doesn't override broader access

Plan

Estimate task consumption and check current billing minimums before setting policy limits.

Monitor

Review the scorecard weekly; monitor usage as risk warrants. Enforcement is asynchronous.

Decide

Weigh credits consumed against the measured value at the go, hold, or pivot gate.

Learn: Plugin FAQ ↗ | Learn: Test a plugin ↗

A8 · TROUBLESHOOTING

Common issues and the first fix to try

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIRST FIX
Skill never triggers	Description lacks the words users say	Add trigger phrases; re-validate; read the Skill Report
Plugin upload rejected	Manifest or skill rule violation	Fix the error; check your manifest schema and required package files
Connector tools missing	Sign-in not completed, or tools/list fails	Sign in; test tools/list; confirm Streamable HTTP
Every action asks to approve	Missing annotations, tool flags, or approval policy	Review annotations and policy; mark only genuine reads as read-only
Users can't open Cowork	No spending policy covers them	Assign a policy scoped to their group
Skill missing on phone	Client support or availability differs	Verify current support; use a supported web or desktop client

A9 · GLOSSARY

Terms used in this guide

TERM	MEANING
Custom skill	A SKILL.md file that teaches Cowork your process, rules, and output format
Plugin	A Microsoft 365 app package that bundles skills and connectors for deployment
Federated Copilot connector	A supported, live connector from the Connectors Gallery
Microsoft plugin connector	A connector provided by a Microsoft plugin, such as Dynamics 365 ERP
Remote MCP connector	A custom HTTPS endpoint that exposes your system's tools to Cowork
MCP annotations	Tool hints such as readOnlyHint that guide confirmation alongside Cowork policy
Skill Report	The result of Cowork's native evaluation: score, gates, and findings
Spending policy	An admin control for who can use Cowork and how many Copilot Credits